

MONCHO UNSCHOOLING

Anime

Unit Study

“Every anime begins as a pencil line on blank paper, so what worlds could your own pencil bring to life?”

Art & Creativity | Language Arts | Math | Music | Geography | History | Life Skills & SEL | Physics | Critical Thinking | Movement & Body

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🧭 **How to use this guide:** This is not a workbook, and there's no answer key — on purpose! Every challenge is an invitation. Pick the ones that spark curiosity, skip the rest, and go find the answers by doing. **AI plans. Kids DO.** 🚀

🎨 ART & CREATIVITY

Every anime starts as a pencil line on blank paper, and these three challenges put that pencil in your hand.

🌊 Challenge 1: Make Your Own Great Wave

🎯 Line and Color

How can just a few bold lines and flat colors make a wave look like it's about to crash? ❓

The Great Wave off Kanagawa is a famous woodblock print by Hokusai, made around 1831, showing a huge wave and Mount Fuji. Look it up in a library book or online and study it for one full minute.

1. Notice the thick dark outlines, the flat colors with no blending, and the wave's curling "claws."
2. Lightly sketch your own big wave in pencil. Add a mountain far behind it, small so it looks distant.
3. Trace over your pencil with a black marker or dark crayon.
4. Fill each shape with one flat color, using only 3 or 4 colors in all.
5. Add three tiny boats or birds so the wave feels even bigger.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw just the wave and a triangle mountain, and use only 2 colors.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Try a different huge force, like a giant cloud, a tornado or a monster's foot, using the same bold outlines and flat colors.

🎞️ Challenge 2: Flipbook Studio

🎯 Animation Basics

How can a stack of sticky notes trick your brain into seeing something move? ❓

You're the animator in a tiny studio, and your pad of sticky notes is your film. A flipbook creates the illusion of motion because your brain blends quickly changing images into movement.

1. Take a pad with at least 20 sticky notes. Start on the LAST page.
2. Draw a simple shape, like a circle or star, near the bottom edge.
3. On the next page up, draw the same shape, but change it a tiny bit: slightly bigger, higher up, or squashed.
4. Keep going page by page, with small changes each time.
5. Hold the sticky edge in one hand and flip with your thumb. Watch it grow, bounce or transform.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make only 10 pages, and have the shape just slide from left to right.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make 30 pages where the shape bounces, squashes when it lands, then changes into a totally different shape.

😃 Challenge 3: Shapes with Feelings

🎯 Character Design

Why does a round character feel friendly while a pointy one feels tricky? ❓

Artists use shape language: circles feel soft and kind, squares feel strong and steady, and triangles feel sharp and sneaky.

1. Pick one main shape for your character's head and body. Is your hero a circle, a square or a triangle?
2. Add hair, clothes and one special detail, like a scarf or a tail.
3. Draw five empty faces in a row with the same head shape.
4. In each one, use ONLY eyes, eyebrows and mouth to show one feeling: happy, sad, angry, surprised and scared.
5. Check each face by covering the other four. Can a friend guess the feeling?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Show only three feelings: happy, sad and angry.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a sixth and seventh feeling that is harder to draw, like sneaky and embarrassed, and try them from the side.

📖 LANGUAGE ARTS

Words can be loud, soft, sparkly, or squishy, and anime and manga are full of words that you can almost hear.

📖 Challenge 1: Doki Doki Sound Shop

🎯 Sound Words

Can a word make you hear something that has no sound at all? ❓

You're a manga sound-effect writer, and your boss needs fresh sounds for a new comic. In Japanese manga, sound words are everywhere: "doki doki" is a beating heart and "kira kira" is sparkling.

1. Hunt for 3 more sound words in a comic, a book, or by listening around your home.
2. Invent 5 sound words of your own, such as one for a cat sneezing or a door that sticks.
3. Draw a 3-panel comic strip and use at least 3 of your invented words in big, bold letters.
4. Make the letters match the feeling: jagged for scary, bubbly for happy.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Invent only 3 sound words and put them in a 2-panel strip.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a "sound dictionary" page that lists each word, how to say it, and what it means.

🎭 Challenge 2: Paper Theatre on the Street

🎯 Oral Storytelling

How can a story be told with only a few cards and a voice? ❓

Long ago in Japan, storytellers traveled the streets with kamishibai, "paper theatre." They slid painted cards in and out of a small wooden stage while they told the tale. You're the street storyteller today.

1. Cut a window in the front of a cardboard box and a slit in the side so cards can slide through.
2. Plan a tale with a beginning, a problem, and an ending, using 6 cards.
3. Draw one scene on each card and write a few lines on the back for yourself.
4. Gather your family, slide the cards out one at a time, and tell the story with different voices.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use 4 cards and tell your story in your own words without reading from the back.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a surprise twist on the last card and ask your audience to guess the ending before you reveal it.

📚 Challenge 3: Read It Backwards

🎯 Reading Direction

What happens to a comic when you read it from the other side? ❓

Manga are Japanese comics, and they're traditionally read from right to left, starting at the back of the book. Everything flips!

1. Fold a sheet of paper into 4 equal boxes.
2. Number the boxes from the right side to the left side: 1 is the top-right box.
3. Tell a tiny story with 4 beats: meet a character, something changes, a problem, a surprise.
4. Draw and write your story, keeping speech bubbles in the order a right-to-left reader would see them.
5. Ask someone to read it the Japanese way. Did they get the story right?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use stick figures and only one short speech bubble per panel.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make the mini-manga 8 panels long and finish with a cliffhanger.

➗ MATH

Anime is built from thousands of drawings, speeds and measurements, so every great scene starts with a little math.

✏️ Challenge 1: The Drawing Budget

🎯 Multiplication and comparing

If you had to draw a whole fight scene by hand, how many pictures would your pencil need to make? ❓

You're the studio planner, and the director wants a 10-second scene. Film shows 24 pictures (frames) every second. Many anime are drawn "on twos," which means each drawing is held for 2 frames, so only about 12 new drawings are needed per second.

1. Calculate the frames in 10 seconds at 24 frames per second.
2. Calculate the drawings needed "on twos" for the same 10 seconds.
3. Subtract to find how many drawings you save.
4. If one drawing takes 5 minutes, work out the total hours for both plans.
5. Write your budget on paper with the two plans side by side, and circle the one you'd choose for a tight deadline.

Why: Holding each drawing for 2 frames still looks smooth to our eyes, so the studio saves half its work.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Plan only a 3-second scene and use a calculator for the hours.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third plan: "on threes," where each drawing is held for 3 frames. Compare all three and plan a 30-second scene.

📐 Challenge 2: Grow Your Drawing

🎯 Ratio and measurement

How can a tiny doodle become a giant poster without getting wobbly or squished? ❓

Artists use the grid method to enlarge a picture exactly, square by square.

1. Draw a simple anime-style face or creature on a small piece of paper, about 8 cm wide.
2. With a ruler, draw a grid of 2 cm squares over it. Count how many squares wide and tall it is.
3. On a bigger sheet, make a grid with the same number of squares, but make each square 6 cm.
4. Copy what's inside each small square into its matching big square, one at a time.
5. Measure the width of your eyes on both drawings. Divide the big number by the small one. Is it the same ratio as your squares?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a 4 × 4 grid and make the big squares exactly double the size.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Enlarge by a ratio of 2.5 instead, and predict the final width before you draw anything.

🗼 Challenge 3: Tokyo Trip Calculator

🎯 Money and time math

If it's breakfast time at your house, what is your favorite anime hero doing in Tokyo? ❓

You're a traveler planning a trip to Tokyo, and you need to understand money and clocks before you go. Use these pretend prices: a ramen bowl costs 900 yen, a train ticket costs 340 yen, and a small figure costs 1,500 yen. Ask an adult for today's exchange rate, or pretend 150 yen equals 1 dollar.

1. Divide each price by the exchange rate to find the cost in your local money.
2. Add up one ramen, two train tickets and one figure.
3. Look up the time difference between your home and Japan on a world clock or map.
4. If it's 8:00 in the morning at home, add or subtract the hours to find Japan's time. Does the date change?
5. Fill in a travel card with your prices and time conversion.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a pretend rate of 100 yen = 1 dollar and convert just two prices.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Plan a full day in Tokyo with 5 purchases and a 20,000 yen budget, then work out how much you'd have left in local money.

🎵 MUSIC

Every anime has a soundtrack and a world of sound effects, and your pencil-drawn worlds need ears to come alive.

🥁 Challenge 1: Build Your Own Taiko Drums

🎯 Rhythm patterns

How can a bucket and a wooden spoon become the heartbeat of a whole group? ❓

Taiko drums are traditional Japanese drums played in groups with strong, powerful rhythm. Time to build your own set!

1. Collect 3 or 4 "drums": an upside-down bucket, a big pot, a plastic tub, a sturdy cardboard box. Use wooden spoons or rolled-up newspaper as sticks.
2. Test each one and sort them from lowest sound to highest.
3. Invent a 4-beat pattern, like BOOM, BOOM, tap-tap, and say it out loud before you play it.
4. Play it as the leader. Your group answers by copying it back (call and response).
5. Now switch leaders and layer two patterns together, one on a low drum and one on a high drum.

Why: bigger, looser surfaces vibrate more slowly, which makes lower sounds. Small, tight surfaces vibrate fast and sound higher.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only two drums and a 2-beat pattern, and clap it first before you hit anything.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write your pattern as boxes on paper (a filled box = a hit, an empty box = a rest) so someone who never heard it can read and play it.

🎭 Challenge 2: Foley Sound-Effects Kit

🎯 Sound design

What if the crunch of snow in a story is really coming from a box of cornstarch? ❓

You're a Foley artist, the person who makes movie sounds live with everyday objects. Foley artists create sound effects with things like crunching cornstarch to sound like footsteps in snow.

1. Gather 6 household objects, such as cornstarch in a bag, a pair of shoes, a sheet of paper, a rice container, a wooden door, a cup of water.
2. Test and label what each one can sound like. Squeeze the cornstarch for snow, crinkle the paper for fire, shake the rice for rain.
3. Make your own sounds for footsteps, wind, a door and rain.
4. Ask a family member to read a short silent-style story (or make one up) while you perform the effects live at just the right moments.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick only 3 effects, and have the reader pause so you have time to find each sound.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a surprise sound the audience must guess, and layer two effects at once, like rain plus distant footsteps.

🎼 Challenge 3: Three-Mood Theme

🎯 Musical mood

How can the same pots and spoons sound calm one moment and scary the next? ❓

Create a short theme with three scenes: calm, danger and joy.

1. Set up your instruments: pots, spoons, a lid, and your own voice (humming, whispering, whooping).
2. For calm, try slow, soft, gentle taps with long hums.
3. For danger, try low, fast, uneven hits with a growly voice.
4. For joy, try bouncy, bright, quick patterns with a high happy sound.
5. Practice each mood for about 10 seconds, then play all three in a row, with a small pause between scenes.

Why: slow and soft sounds relax us, while fast, low and uneven sounds make our bodies feel alert.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make just two moods, calm and joy, and use only your spoons.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a short transition between scenes, like a rising drum roll, and let a friend guess each mood with their eyes closed.

🗾 GEOGRAPHY

Anime stories happen in real places, and Japan's islands, flowers and shaking ground shape the worlds your pencil could draw.

🗻 Challenge 1: Build Japan from Dough

🎯 Map Building

What shape do you get when thousands of islands sit side by side in the sea?❓

Japan is an island country made of four main islands (Hokkaido, Honshu, Shikoku and Kyushu) plus thousands of smaller ones.

1. Mix 2 cups flour, 1 cup salt and about 1 cup water into a smooth dough (or tear newspaper strips and dip them in flour-and-water paste).
2. Look at a map or atlas, then shape the four big islands on a piece of cardboard. Honshu is the long curved one in the middle.
3. Press little bumps along Honshu for mountains.
4. Mark Tokyo, the capital, on Honshu's eastern coast with a bead or a toothpick flag. Add a taller cone for Mount Fuji nearby.
5. Let it dry for a day, then paint the sea blue and the land green and brown.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw the islands on cardboard and fill them in with play dough instead of making salt dough.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add the biggest smaller islands, like Okinawa in the south, and label every island with a tiny paper flag.

🌸 Challenge 2: The Cherry Blossom Trail

🎯 Reading Maps

Why would flowers in one country open on different days depending on where you stand? ❓

You're a flower-viewing tour guide, and your visitors want the best picnic spot in Japan!

Cherry blossoms (sakura) bloom in spring, and the tradition of gathering to enjoy them is called hanami.

1. Find a map of Japan and a list or chart of cherry blossom dates. Search "sakura forecast" and use the picture version.
2. Mark a few cities with blossom dates, such as Fukuoka, Tokyo, Sendai and Sapporo.
3. Draw arrows from the earliest bloom to the latest. Which way does the blossom front travel across the islands?
4. Pick the spot where you'd hold your picnic, then mark it with a star and write the date you'd go and what you'd pack.

Why: warm air arrives first in the south and slowly moves north, and blossoms open when the weather around them has warmed enough.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Compare only three cities and number them 1, 2, 3 in the order they bloom.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Count the days between the first and last bloom on your map, and figure out how many days it takes the blossoms to travel from south to north.

🌋 Challenge 3: Shake, Squish, Survive

🎯 Plate Tectonics

What happens to the ground, and to your building, when two giant pieces of Earth push against each other? ❓

Japan sits where tectonic plates collide, so it has earthquakes and volcanoes, and Mount Fuji is one of those volcanoes.

1. Lay two slabs of modeling clay (or two stacks of towels) on a table, edge to edge.
2. Push them together slowly. Watch what rises, folds and wrinkles. Those are mountains forming.
3. Open a free live earthquake map from the USGS or the Japan Meteorological Agency and look at where the dots cluster around the Japanese islands.
4. Build a tiny tower from marshmallows and toothpicks on a baking tray.
5. Shake the tray. Does it fall? Redesign with triangles, a wider base or shorter floors, and shake again.

Why: when plates push against each other, the ground builds up stress, and when it suddenly slips, the energy shakes everything above it. Triangles hold their shape better than squares, which is why engineers use them in earthquake-ready buildings.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the live map and just do the clay push and one shake test.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Test three different designs and shake each one the same way for 10 seconds, then count which one survives longest.

🏯 HISTORY

Long before streaming, anime grew from simple paper, scissors and big imaginations, and history shows you how.

🎞️ Challenge 1: Cut-Out Pioneer

🎯 Early animation

How could someone make a picture move with nothing but paper and patience? ❓

You're an early animation pioneer in Japan, around 1917. Back then, experiments used simple tricks like cut-out paper and chalk-drawn images. Now it's your turn.

1. Draw a character on paper, with the body, an arm and a leg as separate pieces.
2. Cut the pieces out carefully (ask an adult to help with scissors if needed).
3. Join the arm and leg to the body with brass fasteners, or with a bit of string and tape, so they swing.
4. Place your character on a plain sheet, move one joint a tiny bit, and take a photo. Repeat 10 times.
5. Flip through the photos quickly to watch it move.

Why: your eyes blend photos shown quickly one after another into smooth motion, so small moves between pictures look like real movement.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make just one moving part, like an arm, and take only 5 photos.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second character and a cut-out background, then plan a short scene where they meet.

📜 Challenge 2: The Street Story Seller

🎯 Oral history

How did people hear stories before screens, and what can a grown-up's memories teach you about it? ❓

Long ago in Japan, storytellers traveled through neighborhoods with picture cards to share tales with kids. Let's see how stories reached people in the past.

1. Pick a grown-up you know, in person or by phone.
2. Ask: "How did you hear stories when you were little?" Then ask about their favorite story, who told it, and where.
3. Write or record their answers.
4. Retell their favorite story to someone else, in your own words.
5. Use a loud, lively voice, like a street storyteller calling kids to gather.
6. Compare: how is your grown-up's story-time different from yours today?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Ask only 2 questions and retell just the beginning of their story.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Interview two people from different generations and note one thing that stayed the same and one that changed.

🕰️ Challenge 3: Then and Now Time Capsule

🎯 Timelines

What can an old object tell you about the life of the person who owned it? ❓

Old objects are like clues from the past. Be a history detective and gather evidence from your home.

1. Hunt for an old item at home: a grandparent's watch, a recipe card, a toy or a photo.
2. Ask the object's owner, or an older relative, where it came from, how it was used and what life was like when it was new. Write down the answers.
3. Tape together sheets of paper into a long strip.
4. On one side, draw or write their childhood. On the other, put yours.
5. Tape your old object or photo on as evidence.

Bonus: browse the Japan National Diet Library or Smithsonian digital collections to see how children in Japan once played with spinning tops (koma) or kites (tako), and compare them to your own toys.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Ask just one question about the object and draw the timeline on one sheet of paper.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third section for an even older time, like the childhood of the grown-up's parents, using a second object or photo as evidence.

🤝 LIFE SKILLS & SEL

Anime heroes never win alone, and learning to give thanks, share kindness and work as a team is how you build your own crew in real life.

🍚 Challenge 1: The Thank-You Table

🎯 Gratitude

How many people does it take to get one bowl of rice onto your table?❓

Japanese people say "itadakimasu" before eating, to give thanks for the meal. Plan a family dinner where you say it together.

1. Pick one dish you will help cook, with an adult nearby for the knife and the stove.
2. Before cooking, think of everyone who helped that food reach you: the farmer, the truck driver, the grocery clerk, whoever paid for it.
3. Write each helper on a paper strip.
4. Loop the strips together into a paper chain and hang it over the table.
5. Sit down, say "itadakimasu" together, and have each person name one helper from the chain before the first bite.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Name just three helpers out loud with no writing, and use one simple dish like rice balls.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Trace one ingredient back as far as you can, from the table to the store to the farm, and add each step to your chain.

🕊️ Challenge 2: Wish Crane Mail

🎯 Kindness

Can a small piece of folded paper change how someone feels today? ❓

Origami is the Japanese art of paper folding, and the traditional paper crane is a symbol of peace and good wishes. Make cranes that carry good wishes to people who need cheering up.

1. Choose three people who could use a smile, such as a grandparent, a neighbor, or a friend having a hard week.
2. Cut a square of paper for each one. Any paper works, like wrapping paper or a magazine page.
3. Write a kind message on the plain side of each square before you fold it.
4. Fold each crane by following a book or video tutorial. Go slowly and crease every fold sharply.
5. Deliver each crane in person, or tuck it into an envelope.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Fold a simple origami heart or boat instead of a crane, and keep the message to one sentence.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Fold a whole string of cranes for a place that needs cheer, like a hospital or senior center, and ask an adult how to deliver them.

🏮 Challenge 3: Family Matsuri Day

🎯 Teamwork

What does it feel like when everyone in a group has an important job? ❓

You're the festival organizer. Japanese festivals (matsuri) often include dancing such as bon odori, lanterns, drums and street food stalls, so pick at least three of those ideas for your own mini matsuri.

1. Hold a family meeting and give every person a role, such as game master, lantern maker, snack cook, or drummer.
2. Make paper lanterns from folded construction paper, with a paper strip handle on top.
3. Invent two simple games, like tossing beanbags into a bucket or fishing paper fish with a magnet.
4. Set up your stalls and run the festival for 30 minutes.
5. Afterward, ask everyone to finish this sentence on an index card: "Working together felt like..."

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Run just one game and one lantern with two roles, and say your feeling out loud instead of writing it.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Invite neighbors or friends, give each guest a job, and ask them what they would do differently next time.

⚡ PHYSICS

Anime is full of flying, falling and glowing shadows, and every one of them follows the same forces you can test with your own hands.

✈️ Challenge 1: Paper Plane Flight Lab

🎯 Testing Variables

What makes one folded plane glide across the room while another nosedives straight to the floor? ❓

Japan has a famous paper-folding tradition, and there are even paper-plane champions. Time to run your own tryouts.

1. Fold three planes from the same kind of paper: a dart, a wide-wing glider, and one of your own design.
2. Stand on one spot and launch each plane three times. Throw with the same push every time.
3. Put a sticky note or a piece of tape where each plane lands. Measure each distance with a tape measure or count your footsteps.
4. Pick your best plane and change just ONE thing: add a small paperclip to the nose, or bend the back edges up a little.
5. Launch it three more times. Mark the landings and compare. Did the change help or hurt?
6. Draw a chart or a sketch map of the landing marks, circle the winning plane, and write the one change that helped most.

Why: wings push air downward, and the air pushes the plane up. That push is lift. Drag is the air rubbing against the plane and slowing it down.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Test only two planes, launch each one time, and just say which one flew farther.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Take the average of your three throws for each plane, then try three different paperclip positions (nose, middle, tail) and find the best spot.

🔦 Challenge 2: Shadow Puppet Theater

🎯 Light and Shadow

How can you make a shadow giant, tiny, fuzzy or razor-sharp without changing the puppet at all?❓

Darkness plus one light is all you need for a stage.

1. Cut a simple character from cardboard (a cat, a dragon, a hero) and tape it to a pencil or craft stick.
2. In a dim room, aim a flashlight at a blank wall or a white sheet.
3. Hold the puppet close to the wall, far from the light. Look at the shadow's size and edges, then measure its height with a ruler.
4. Slide the puppet toward the flashlight a little at a time. Stop every 20 cm, measure the shadow, and write down what you notice about size and sharpness.
5. Use what you learned to plan a short scene: a tiny hero facing a giant monster, using only distance to change their sizes.
6. Act it out and keep your distance notes next to it.

Why: light travels in straight lines. The closer the puppet is to the light, the more light it blocks, so the shadow spreads wider and gets blurrier.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use your hand as the puppet and just say whether the shadow gets bigger or smaller as you move closer to the light.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second flashlight and a second puppet, and find the distances where the two shadows overlap or touch.

🏀 Challenge 3: Heavy or Light? Drop Test

🎯 Observing Motion

How can the very same falling ball look as heavy as a boulder or as light as a balloon? ❓

Animators bend objects as they move to trick your eyes. Test it with real things, outside if you can.

1. Gather a tennis ball, a rubber ball, a ball of crumpled paper and a heavy object like a stone or an apple.
2. Drop each from the same height onto the ground. Watch closely: which one squashes when it lands, and which one barely changes?
3. Film each drop in slow motion with a phone, or watch twice and sketch what you see in 4 or 5 quick positions.
4. Notice how the bouncy ball changes shape and how the heavy object just thuds.
5. Now draw a ball that looks heavy and a ball that looks light, showing its squash and stretch on every drawing.
6. Put your drawings in order on one sheet, with arrows showing the motion.

Why: a soft, bouncy object squashes when it hits the ground and then springs back, so it feels light. A hard, heavy object barely changes shape, so it feels solid and heavy.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Test just two objects and draw only one position of each, at the moment it hits the ground.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Drop each object from two different heights and compare how much each one squashes and how high it bounces back.

🧠 CRITICAL THINKING

Great anime artists don't just draw what they see, they make careful choices about what to show, what to hide, and what the audience will figure out on their own.

🎬 Challenge 1: Direct a Silent Scene

🎯 Clear communication

Can six drawings alone make someone understand your story? ❓

You're a director with one rule: no words allowed.

1. Invent a tiny scene with a beginning, a middle and an end (a lost cat finds its way home, a robot learns to dance).
2. Fold a sheet of paper into 6 boxes and sketch one moment in each. Stick figures are fine.
3. Show the story through faces, poses and objects, not text.
4. Swap with someone and ask them to tell you the story out loud.
5. Compare. Where did they get confused? Redraw that box to fix it.

Why: your brain fills gaps with what it already knows, so one unclear picture can send a viewer down a totally different path.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only 4 boxes and a story with one clear event, like a ball rolling away and being caught.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make a story with a twist in box 5 that changes how the viewer understands boxes 1 through 4.

🔍 Challenge 2: Fact, Opinion or Guess?

🎯 Sorting claims

How do you know when a sentence is something you can prove and when it's only something you believe? ❓

Pick any scene from a manga page, a short anime clip, or a picture book.

1. Write 6 sentences about the scene on separate paper strips, like "The hero is brave," "The sky is purple," and "The villain is probably lonely."
2. Sort the strips into three piles: fact (you can prove it by looking), opinion (people may feel differently), and prediction (you're guessing what happens next or why).
3. Trade strips with someone else and see if they sort them the same way.
4. Argue kindly about any strips you disagree on. What evidence would change your mind?
5. Photograph your three labeled piles, circle one strip you and your partner disagreed on, and add a note on why.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write only 3 strips, one of each kind, and sort them with a grown-up.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Rewrite one opinion strip so it becomes a fact (change "brave" into something you can point to in the picture), then rewrite one fact strip so it becomes an opinion.

🕵️ Challenge 3: The Mystery Panel

🎯 Evidence vs. assumption

When part of a picture is missing, how much of what you "see" is really in your head? ❓

1. On a sheet of paper, draw one scene with a clear clue, like muddy footprints, an open window, and a half-eaten snack on a table.
2. Cover parts of it with sticky notes or small paper squares so only some of the drawing shows.
3. Give it to a friend and ask them to write down what happened.
4. Remove one cover at a time. After each reveal, ask: what did you see for sure, and what did you assume?
5. Make two lists: "Shown in the picture" and "Guessed by the viewer."

Why: your brain loves to complete patterns, so it often fills in missing pieces without telling you.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Hide just two spots and give your friend two choices to pick from, like "a dog did it" or "a cat did it."

🚀 **Level it Up:** Draw a second version where one small change makes the opposite guess seem right, and see if your friend is fooled.

🤸 MOVEMENT & BODY

Anime characters leap, spin and dance across the screen, and every one of those moves started as a real body moving in space.

🪩 Challenge 1: Teach the Circle Dance

🎯 Coordination

How can a few simple steps, repeated in a circle, make a whole group move as one? ❓

Many festival dances use a short pattern of steps that repeats again and again, so anyone can join in. Make up your own.

1. Invent four steps: step right, step left, step forward, step back. Practice them until you don't need to think.
2. Add an arm pattern: two claps, then both arms sweeping up like a wave.
3. Put the steps and arms together in a count of eight. Say the count out loud as you dance.
4. Gather your family in a circle, show the pattern slowly, then dance it together a few times, a little faster each round.

Why: repeating a pattern lets your body remember the moves, so your brain is free to enjoy the group.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only three steps and skip the arm pattern until everyone has the feet down.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second part that changes direction halfway through, so the circle spins the other way.

⚡ Challenge 2: Five Poses, Five Seconds

🎯 Balance and Control

What makes a pose look powerful, even when you are completely still? ❓

Grab a pencil, paper and a helper.

1. Pick five action moves: a leap, a punch, a dodge, a spin, a landing.
2. Strike the first pose, stretch it big, and freeze. Hold for a slow count of five without wobbling.
3. While you hold, your helper makes a quick gesture drawing: just flowing lines for the body, no details, finished before you move.
4. Repeat for all five poses, then switch places so you can draw too.

Why: a bent knee, a twisted back and one arm reaching far give a pose its feeling of motion, even when you are frozen.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Hold each pose for a count of three, and draw simple stick figures.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Link all five poses into one smooth sequence, then hold the last one for a slow count of ten.

🚶 Challenge 3: Slow-Motion Walk Cycle

🎯 Body Awareness

How many different positions are hiding inside one single step? ❓

Animators don't draw a walk as one motion. They break it into key positions. Find a clear hallway, yard or sidewalk.

1. Walk normally and notice what your legs, arms and head do.
2. Now walk in super slow motion, so slow that one step takes a count of eight.
3. Stop at 8 moments: the heel touches down, the body sinks, the leg passes under you, the body rises, and so on. Have a helper call "freeze" each time.
4. At each freeze, notice where your feet, knees, arms and head are. Draw a quick stick figure for each one, in order, in a row of 8 boxes.

Why: while one foot is down, your other arm swings forward to balance you, so every position leads smoothly into the next.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Freeze in only 4 positions and draw 4 simple stick figures.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Repeat the cycle while jogging, and compare how the 8 positions change.